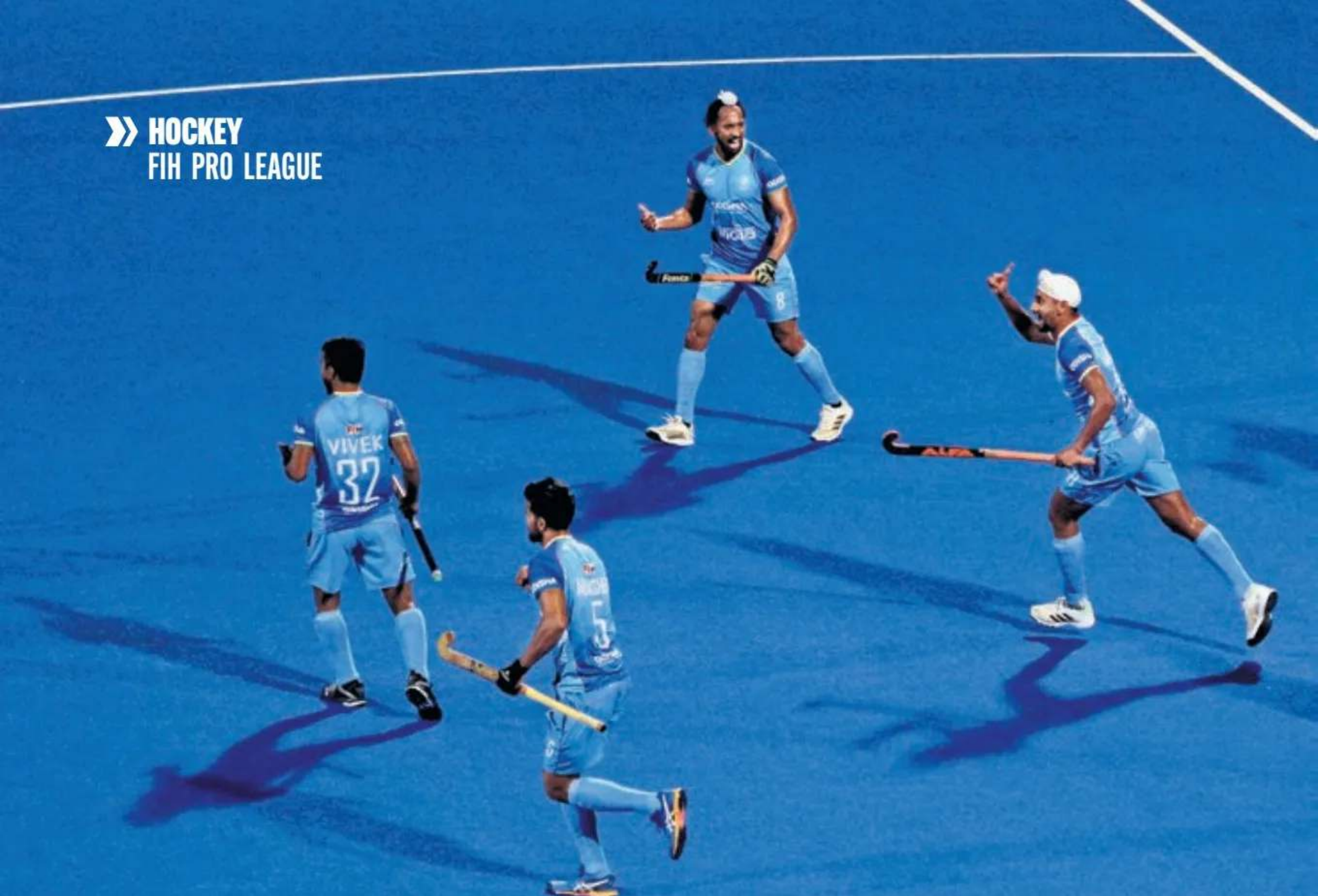




A FIELD OF CONTRASTS

The FIH Pro League revealed **starkly different trajectories** for the Indian men's and women's hockey teams, reflecting their struggles and aspirations both on and off the field.

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When the Indian men and women returned to Bhubaneswar for the 2023-24 season of the FIH Pro League at the beginning of February, the contrast between them could not have been more stark. Their performances on the field over the next 25 days, to a large extent, mirrored their

differences off it.

On the one hand, the men returned to their favourite ground to kick-start preparations for the Paris Olympics, fine-tuning plans and personnel and entering the home stretch of finding the final pieces that will, hopefully, see them atop the podium for a second successive time. The eight games — spread across Bhubaneswar and Rourkela — were also going to be their last bit of action at home before setting out on the journey to Paris.

Goals galore: The match against Australia was a 10-goal fest that saw India come back from deficit to take the lead, only to see it melt away.

BISWARANJAN ROUT